End of the Beginning?

The ceasefire's outcome will have profound consequences for the future of the Gulf states, regional peace and the global economy



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The two-week ceasefire agreed to between the United States and Iran late on April 7 has provided a much-needed respite for a conflict that was spiralling frighteningly out of control. For six weeks prior, bewildered populations around the globe—particularly those in south and east Asia most acutely affected by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz—had anxiously monitored the news, hoping for a positive sign. Their anxiety was exacerbated by the fact that the war's goals remain undefined, including whether there was any alignment amongst the US, Israel and the Gulf states on the desired outcome. Using his 'Madman Theory' of negotiations, President Donald Trump has employed highly disturbing and apocalyptic language—threatening the end of Iranian civilisation—when launching attacks which could have constituted war crimes. Israel, for its part, appears bent on transforming Iran into a failed state which would take decades to rebuild. Iran's objectives have been clear: regime survival, no matter the cost to Iranian civilians or external populations. For the six Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states—Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates—who are among America's closest allies in the region, the war has already destroyed years of careful investment in the security and prosperity of their citizenry.

Washington's relations with the Gulf go as far back as the 1930s, when American companies helped with the exploration and exploitation of the region's vast oil reserves. Ties accelerated when Great Britain withdrew from east of Suez; the US Navy took over the port facility previously occupied by the British Royal Navy in Bahrain in 1971, a base which is now home to over 8,000 US military personnel and their families. In the ensuing years, the US military established bases throughout the area, including the forward headquarters for US Central Command in Qatar, and installations in Kuwait, the UAE and Saudi Arabia—many of which have sustained serious damage from Iranian missile and drone attacks. The GCC bloc itself was established in 1981 as a bulwark against the menace posed by Iran. Today, four GCC states—Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and Saudi Arabia—are designated by the US as Major Non-NATO Allies, a status which provides preferential access to certain American defence articles. The UAE—like India—is a Major Defence Partner, which also conveys defence trade and cooperation privileges.

The Sunni Gulf states, even during the period of the Shah, have always viewed Shi'a Iran as a threat due to its large population (now over 90 million) and formidable military power. Following the 1979 revolution that brought the Islamic